







ROOTED IN CREATIVITY
(clockwise from left) Chu-Liquid States by Philipp Frank; an untitled artwork made from old notebooks, cardboard and clay by Skarma Sonam Tashi; 'River of Sweat', made with recycled sarees, by Anshu Singh; (inset) festival co-curator Raki Nikahetiya

ART

High on Art

The first edition of Sa Ladakh—'the highest festival of land art in Asia'—put the spotlight on climate change and art praxis in a fragile setting

Leh's Disko Valley Bike Park, whose dirt tracks are popular with mountain bikers, was the unlikely address for the first edition of Sa Ladakh, a land art festival where artists worked with recycled and renewable materials to create art focused on "the intersection of climate, culture and community in high-altitude environments". The festival ran through August, concluding with a rousing closing ceremony on August 23 that had the audience tapping to, you guessed it, disco beats. The festival, which had about 10 major installations, was curated by Dr Monisha Ahmed, co-founder of Ladakh Media and Arts Organisation (LAMO) and Sri Lankan artist Raki Nikahetiya, who also exhibited at the festival.

Anshu Singh's arresting 'River of Sweat'—fashioned from strips of sarees woven together—reflected on the harsh realities faced by weavers and craftsmen in the wake of fast fashion. Vibha Galhotra's artwork was one of the most striking—and not only for its sheer size. The open-ended installation titled 'You Don't Own Me!' spelt out exactly that message in recycled fabric. Co-curator Nikahetiya's own 'For a Fifty Million Years' used the rammed earth technique to create a layered artwork that was a commentary on geological time. Kargil-based Anayat Ali's 'Sacred Place', a gravity-defying arrangement of rocks and pebbles, was a meditation on Ladakh's fragile and changing ecology. There was no starker meditation on fragility than Arunima Dazees Wangchuk's 'What if we prayed to the mountains?'. Made with materials like clay, wire, wood, rope, stones and rocks, the figure squatting in prayer cracked and crumbled through the course of the festival.

Installations in the land art movement are not necessarily meant to last

A cornerstone of the land art movement is that the installations are not necessarily meant to last or be transportable. Some will crumble, others will be removed, and yet others can be repurposed. Tundup Gyatso's 'Kicker of Plastics', a mountain biking ramp made from plastic bottles, saw use by enthusiastic bikers even during the festival. Gurmet Kungyam's 'Bayul', made with broken mirrors and named for the hidden fairy lands of Ladakhi lore, doubled up as the stage for the closing music concert by Ladakhi band Dashugs.

The highlight of the closing ceremony was a mesmerising projection inspired by flowing water by German light artist Philipp Frank. Accompanying it was an ambient music track combining the sounds of electronica with a plaintive Ladakhi instrument that was contributed by Sebastian Fuchs, the multi-hyphenate spokesperson of the German embassy in New Delhi, who is known on the DJ circuit as Barten.

At 3,600 metres, Sa Ladakh is being touted as Asia's highest land art exhibition. The festival raised critical questions about the practice of art in a fragile landscape. The stark setting—a backdrop of towering crags and cerulean sky above—drove home the point. And if the festival needed a raison d'etre, it had it in Leh's blistering heat. ■

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